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Russian-Persian Language Interference: A Contrastive Approach to Teaching Russian as a Foreign Language

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Abstract

Language interference is one of the central problems in the process of learning foreign languages, since the system of the learner's native language exerts a significant influence on the perception, acquisition, and use of the new language. This article examines Russian-Persian language interference from the standpoint of a contrastive approach to teaching Russian as a foreign language. The aim of the study is to identify the main types of interference phenomena arising from differences between the Russian and Persian linguistic systems, as well as to determine their significance for the methodology of teaching Russian to Persian-speaking learners.

The study analyzes phonetic, grammatical, lexical, and syntactic differences between Russian and Persian that may lead to errors in the learning process. Particular attention is paid to such linguistic categories as the case system, grammatical gender, the category of verbal aspect, word order, and the features of the phonetic organization of speech.

The theoretical foundation of the research is based on the principles of the theory of language interference and contrastive linguistics. On the basis of the analysis conducted, methodological strategies aimed at preventing and overcoming the negative transfer of elements of the native language in the study of Russian as a foreign language are proposed.

The results of the study show that the systematic consideration of differences between Russian and Persian contributes to increasing the effectiveness of teaching Russian, developing linguistic competence, and reducing the number of typical errors among Persian-speaking students.

Keywords: Russian as a foreign language, Persian language, language interference, contrastive analysis, error analysis, Russian for Persian-speaking learners, foreign language teaching methodology.

Introduction

The study of the Russian language by native speakers of Persian is accompanied by linguistic and methodological difficulties caused by differences between the two language systems. Despite belonging to the Indo-European family, Russian and Persian belong to different language branches and differ substantially in phonetics, grammar, syntax, and lexicon.

One of the key factors influencing the acquisition of Russian is language interference—the transfer of elements of the native language into foreign speech. Among Persian-speaking learners this manifests itself in persistent errors conditioned by structural differences between the two languages.

The analysis of such errors makes it possible to identify the causes of learning difficulties and to develop more effective methods of teaching Russian as a foreign language.

The aim of the study is to identify the main types of Russian-Persian language interference and to determine the possibilities of applying a contrastive approach in teaching Russian to Iranian students.

To achieve this aim the following tasks are addressed:

— to define the theoretical foundations of the study of language interference;

— to identify the main differences between Russian and Persian;

— to characterize the principal zones of interference;

— to propose methodological ways of preventing and overcoming interference errors.

The research is based on the methods of contrastive analysis, error analysis, and linguodidactic description of linguistic material. The results obtained can be used in the development of teaching materials and methodological recommendations for teaching Russian to Persian-speaking students.

2. Research Methods

The study was carried out within the framework of qualitative linguistic analysis and is based on the use of contrastive, descriptive, and linguodidactic methods. The combined application of these methods made it possible to identify the main features of Russian-Persian language interference and to determine their significance for teaching Russian as a foreign language.

The principal research method is the contrastive analysis of Russian and Persian. This approach is based on the principles of contrastive linguistics, according to which the comparison of language systems allows potential difficulties in the acquisition of a foreign language to be identified (Lado 1957: 1–9). The comparison of their phonetic, grammatical, lexical, and syntactic features made it possible to determine the linguistic phenomena that most frequently become sources of interference errors among Persian-speaking learners.

To explain the mechanisms of error emergence, the method of error analysis (Corder 1967: 161–170), widely used in research on second and foreign language acquisition, was employed. The analysis of typical deviations from the norms of the Russian language made it possible to establish a connection between the features of the learners' native language and the nature of the resulting interference phenomena (James 1998: 62–65).

A descriptive method was also applied in the work for the systematization of linguistic facts and the characterization of the main types of interference. The methodological aspect of the research is based on the principles of modern linguodidactics and the methodology of teaching Russian as a foreign language, oriented toward the prevention of interference through the conscious comparison of language systems.

Thus, the combination of contrastive analysis, error analysis, and linguodidactic description ensures a comprehensive approach to the study of Russian-Persian language interference and makes it possible to formulate practical recommendations for teaching Persian-speaking students Russian. Such a combination of methods corresponds to contemporary approaches to the investigation of cross-linguistic influence and the formation of the learner's interlanguage (Selinker 1972: 214).

3. Theoretical Foundations of Language Interference

The theoretical foundation of the research consists of the principles of contrastive linguistics, the theory of language transfer, and the methodology of teaching Russian as a foreign language.

In modern linguistics, interference is regarded as the result of the interaction of the native and the target languages. It arises when the features of the first language influence the perception and use of the foreign language. Such influence may be either positive,

facilitating the acquisition of certain linguistic phenomena, or negative, causing persistent errors (Weinreich 1953: 1–3).

For speakers of Persian, the study of Russian is complicated by substantial differences in the grammatical and phonetic organization of the two languages. Persian is predominantly analytical in character, whereas Russian is distinguished by a developed system of inflection and grammatical categories (Maslov 1987: 45–47).

Contrastive linguistics makes it possible to identify differences between languages and to predict typical learning difficulties, which serves as a basis for the development of effective methodological techniques for preventing interference errors (Lado 1957: 2–9).

From a psycholinguistic point of view, interference is connected with the transfer of linguistic models of the native language into the process of mastering a foreign language. This is especially noticeable in the absence of analogous grammatical or phonological categories in the native language and is reflected in the formation of the learner's "interlanguage" (Selinker 1972: 214).

The most significant differences between Russian and Persian are connected with the category of gender, the absence of a case system in Persian, features of phonological organization, word order, and cultural-pragmatic norms of communication.

Thus, the study of interference requires a comprehensive linguistic and methodological approach. The comparison of Russian and Persian makes it possible to explain the causes of typical errors and to determine effective teaching strategies that take into account the features of the learners' native language (Shcherba 1974: 92).

3. Definitions of Key Concepts

To ensure conceptual clarity, this study defines the key constructs underpinning the proposed framework as interrelated components of literature-mediated foreign language learning. Intercultural Communicative Competence (ICC) refers to the ability to communicate effectively and appropriately across linguistic and cultural contexts. Building on communicative competence (Canale & Swain, 1980; Hymes, 1972), Byram (1997, 2021) defines ICC as the integration of attitudes, knowledge, interpretive and interactional skills, and critical cultural awareness. In this study, ICC represents the intended outcome of literature-mediated Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) instruction. Literary texts are authentic cultural artifacts that combine linguistic, cultural,

and aesthetic meanings within realistic communicative contexts (Carter & Long, 1991; Hall, 2015; Lazar, 1993). Their dialogic nature (Bakhtin, 1981) and readers' active role in meaning-making (Iser, 1978) encourage learners to interpret language beyond its literal level and develop intercultural understanding through reflection and dialogue.

Pedagogical mediation refers to instructional processes that support knowledge construction through interaction with texts, teachers, and peers. Drawing on Sociocultural Theory (Lantolf & Thorne, 2006; Vygotsky, 1978) and the CEFR Companion Volume (Council of Europe, 2020), it involves interpreting information, negotiating meaning, and facilitating collaborative learning. Within this framework, literary texts function as the primary mediating tool. Integrated Competence Development (ICD), the central construct of this study, describes the reciprocal development of linguistic competence, intercultural understanding, and critical interpretation. These dimensions evolve simultaneously through literary engagement, reinforcing one another in a unified learning process.

Russian as a Foreign Language (RFL) refers to the teaching and learning of Russian by non-native speakers in formal educational settings. Contemporary RFL pedagogy emphasizes communicative competence, intercultural awareness, authentic language use, and the inseparable relationship between language and culture (Azimov & Shchukin, 2009; Safonova, 2014; Shchukin, 2015; Vereshchagin & Kostomarov, 2005). Together, these concepts constitute a coherent theoretical model in which literary texts mediate Integrated Competence Development, ultimately fostering Intercultural Communicative Competence in university-level RFL education.

3.1. Positive and Negative Interference

In the process of learning a foreign language, the influence of the native language system may be either positive or negative. Positive interference facilitates the acquisition of linguistic material thanks to similarities in grammatical, phonetic, and lexical elements of the two languages (Lado 1957: 9–15).

In Russian-Persian linguistic interaction, negative interference predominates, arising from the transfer of features of the native language into foreign speech. It is most noticeable in the absence of direct correspondences between the linguistic categories of Russian and Persian (Weinreich 1953: 7–9).

Among Persian-speaking students, difficulties are most often connected with the category of gender, the case system, verbal aspect, the opposition of hard and soft consonants, and word order (Odlin 1989: 27–30).

From a linguodidactic point of view, the analysis of interference makes it possible to predict typical errors and to develop exercises aimed at their prevention and elimination (Shchukin 2003: 115–117).

Thus, the study of interference should be directed not only toward the description of errors but also toward the identification of the mechanisms of their emergence, taking into account the features of both languages. Therefore, the further analysis of Russian-Persian interference is conducted at the phonetic, lexical, grammatical, syntactic, and pragmatic levels.

4. Russian-Persian Language Interference: Main Zones of Manifestation

Russian-Persian language interference represents the systemic influence of the learner's native language on the process of mastering Russian as a foreign language. Its manifestations encompass various levels of the language system and are connected primarily with differences between the structure of Russian and Persian. The investigation of such differences makes it possible to predict possible learning difficulties and to develop special methodological strategies (Weinreich 1953: 15–18).

4.1. Phonetic Interference

Phonetic interference is one of the first forms of manifestation of the influence of the native language. The greatest difficulties for Persian-speaking learners are connected with sounds and phonological features of Russian that are absent from the Persian system. These differences often lead to a persistent accent and pronunciation errors (Sokolova & Ganshina 1980: 25–27).

The main difficulties include the pronunciation of the sound [y], the distinction between hard and soft consonants, Russian stress, and consonant clusters. For example:

м ы → м и

с ы н → с и н

Difficulties also arise in distinguishing pairs such as угол — уголь, брат — брать. To overcome them, exercises for the development of phonemic perception, articulation, and auditory control are necessary (Shcherba 1974: 105).

4.2. Lexical Interference

Lexical interference is conditioned by differences in the meaning and use of words. Persian-speaking learners often transfer semantic models of the native language, which leads to errors in the choice of words and their combinability (Dolgova 2010: 34–36).

Particular difficulties are caused by verbs of motion (идти — ходить, ехать — ездить) and the category of aspect (читать — прочитать, делать — сделать). The absence of a complete correspondence of these categories in Persian leads to the mixing of the meanings of completeness and duration of an action (Maslov 1987: 214–216).

4.3. Grammatical Interference

The grammatical system of Russian presents considerable difficulties for speakers of Persian owing to the absence in the latter of the categories of gender, cases, and a number of verbal forms.

Typical errors of agreement include:

новый книга

новый окно

as well as violations of case government:

Я читаю книга.

Such errors are explained by the transfer of the structure of the native language, in which grammatical relations are predominantly expressed by analytical means (Lado 1957: 34–36; Vinogradov 1972: 68–70).

4.4. Syntactic and Pragmatic Interference

Syntactic interference is conditioned by differences in sentence construction. Persian is characterized by the subject–object–verb order, whereas in Russian word order is freer and is determined by the communicative task (Maslov 1987: 301–303).

Pragmatic interference manifests itself in the use of forms of address, the expression of requests, and means of politeness. Therefore, the formation of communicative competence presupposes the mastery not only of grammatical but also of sociocultural norms of the Russian language (Galskova & Gez 2006: 215–217).

Thus, the main manifestations of Russian-Persian interference cover the phonetic, lexical, grammatical, and syntactic-pragmatic levels. Taking them into account makes it possible to predict typical errors and to increase the effectiveness of teaching Russian as a foreign language.

5. Contrastive Analysis of Russian and Persian

The contrastive analysis of Russian and Persian constitutes an important foundation for identifying potential zones of interference in the process of teaching Russian as a foreign language. Despite belonging to the Indo-European family, the two languages differ substantially in their structural organization, which exerts a direct influence on the process of the acquisition of Russian by Persian-speaking learners (Lado 1957: 11–15).

Russian belongs to the East Slavic group and is characterized by a developed system of inflection, the presence of grammatical gender, a case system, and the category of verbal aspect. Persian belongs to the Iranian group and possesses predominantly analytical features, in which many grammatical meanings are expressed by means of separate elements rather than through changes in word form (Maslov 1987: 45–47).

5.1. Phonetic Differences

The Russian phonological system is distinguished by the presence of categories that are absent or only limitedly represented in Persian, above all the opposition of hard and soft consonants and the sound [y]. These differences become one of the causes of pronunciation errors among Persian-speaking students (Sokolova & Ganshina 1980: 32–35).

Table 1

Phonetic Differences between Russian and Persian and Possible Interference Errors

Russian Language	Feature	Possible Error of Persian-Speaking Learners
брат — брать	Distinction of hardness and softness of the consonant	Confusion of sounds
угол — уголь	Distinction of meaning through softness of the consonant	Loss of semantic distinction
был — бил	Distinction of the vowels [y] and [i]	Replacement of [y] by the sound [i]
сын — син	Absence of the sound [y] in Persian	Incorrect pronunciation

In addition, Russian stress presents a certain difficulty for Persian-speaking learners, since its functioning differs from the Persian system. Unlike Persian, where stress has a more stable character, in Russian it is mobile and may perform a meaning-distinguishing function (Shcherba 1974: 118–120).

5.2. Morphological Differences

The most significant differences between Russian and Persian are observed in the area of grammar. The absence in Persian of certain Russian grammatical categories is one of the main causes of persistent errors in the study of Russian as a foreign language (Vinogradov 1972: 68–70).

Table 2

Main Morphological Differences between Russian and Persian

Grammatical Category	Russian Language	Persian Language	Possible Interference
Gender of nouns	Masculine, feminine, neuter	Grammatical gender is absent	Errors in agreement (новый книга, большой окно)
Case system	Six cases (nominative, genitive, dative, accusative, instrumental, prepositional)	No case system in the Russian sense	Incorrect use of case endings (читать книга, иду в университета)
Verbal aspect	Perfective and imperfective aspect (читать — прочитать, делать — сделать)	No complete correspondence to the Russian category of aspect	Mixing of aspectual forms and difficulties in expressing completeness of action
Agreement of words	Adjectives, pronouns, and numerals agree with nouns in gender, number, and case	Agreement is limited	Errors in word combinations (новый книга, интересная фильм)

Differences in grammatical structure require special methodological work, since learners often attempt to apply models of the native language when constructing Russian utterances (Shchukin 2003: 120–122).

In addition to phonetic and grammatical differences, the syntactic features of the two languages are of great importance. In Russian, word order is relatively free, whereas in Persian the predominant structure is:

subject + object + predicate

This difference may lead to the transfer of the structure of the native language into Russian speech.

Thus, the contrastive analysis shows that the main difficulties of Persian-speaking learners are connected not only with the absence of individual linguistic categories but also with differences in the ways of organizing linguistic material.

5.3. Lexico-Semantic Differences

Lexico-semantic differences between Russian and Persian constitute an important source of language interference. They manifest themselves in the features of word meaning, combinability, and use in various communicative situations.

Russian is characterized by the polysemy of words and a developed system of set expressions whose meaning depends on context. The absence of direct correspondences often leads to the transfer of semantic models of the native language and the inaccurate use of words (Karaulov 1987: 52–54).

Particular difficulties are caused by verbs of motion and aspectual pairs that lack a complete correspondence in Persian. As a result, learners make errors in conveying the direction of movement, repetition, or completeness of an action (Maslov 1987: 214–216).

Problems also arise in the use of set expressions and phraseological units, the literal translation of which frequently violates the norms of the Russian language.

Thus, the contrastive analysis of the lexico-semantic features of Russian and Persian makes it possible to identify the main zones of interference and to take them into account in the development of teaching materials and methodological recommendations for teaching Russian as a foreign language.

5.4. Syntactic and Pragmatic Differences

Alongside phonetic, morphological, and lexico-semantic features, syntactic and pragmatic differences between Russian and Persian play a substantial role in the emergence of interference. They manifest themselves not only in sentence structure but also in the ways of organizing speech communication.

One of the most noticeable differences is word order. Persian is characterized by the model “subject – object – predicate” (SOV), whereas in Russian, thanks to the developed system of inflection, word order is considerably freer. A change in the sequence of sentence components in Russian is often connected with the actual division of the utterance and the communicative intention of the speaker, whereas in Persian such changes have a more limited character (Maslov 1987: 301–303).

Pragmatic differences manifest themselves in the use of forms of address, the expression of politeness, and the choice of communicative strategies. Despite the presence in both languages of an opposition between formal and informal forms of communication, the rules of their use do not always coincide. As a result, Persian-speaking learners may experience difficulties in choosing forms of address, constructing requests, expressing gratitude, or refusal in accordance with the norms of Russian speech etiquette (Galskova & Gez 2006: 215–217).

The contrastive analysis of syntactic and pragmatic features makes it possible to explain the causes of many communicative errors that cannot be interpreted solely from the point of view of grammar. Taking these differences into account contributes to the formation not only of linguistic but also of communicative competence of learners, which is one of the main goals of teaching Russian as a foreign language.

6. Research Results and Discussion

The contrastive analysis of Russian and Persian made it possible to identify the main regularities of the emergence of interference phenomena in the process of teaching Russian as a foreign language. The results obtained show that the majority of errors of Persian-speaking learners are systemic in character and are conditioned by structural differences between the two language systems (Weinreich 1953: 15–18).

The most significant zones of interference are found in the areas of grammar, phonetics, lexicon, and syntax. The degree of influence of the native language depends on the level of proficiency in Russian, the linguistic experience of the learners, and the degree of similarity or difference of concrete linguistic categories (Odlin 1989: 27–30).

6.1. Grammatical Interference as the Main Zone of Difficulty

The results of the study show that the grammatical level is one of the most complex areas for Persian-speaking learners. This is connected primarily with typological differences between Russian and Persian: Russian is characterized by a developed system of inflection, whereas Persian possesses a predominantly analytical structure (Maslov 1987: 45–47).

The absence in Persian of the category of grammatical gender leads to persistent errors in the agreement of nouns with adjectives, pronouns, and numerals. Learners often use a

single form of the adjective instead of changing the form according to the gender of the noun:

Correct forms:

новый дом

новая книга

новое окно

Typical errors:

новый книга

новый окно

Such errors are explained by the transfer of the model of the native language, in which nouns have no grammatical gender and modifiers do not change according to the gender of the modified word (Lado 1957: 34–36).

Considerable difficulties are also caused by the acquisition of the Russian case system. Since Persian lacks an analogous system of inflection, learners experience difficulties in choosing case endings and verb government:

Russian norm:

Я читаю книгу.

Я интересуюсь русской культурой.

Interference errors:

Я читаю книга.

Я интересуюсь русский культура.

These errors testify to the transfer of analytical models of Persian onto the inflectional system of Russian (Vinogradov 1972: 68–70).

6.2. Phonetic Interference and Pronunciation Problems

The analysis of phonetic difficulties shows that the main errors are connected with the absence in the Persian phonological system of certain Russian oppositions. The most

complex for Persian-speaking learners are the sound [y], the distinction between hard and soft consonants, and the features of Russian stress (Sokolova & Ganshina 1980: 25–27).

For example, the replacement of the sound [y] by the sound [i] leads to distortion of pronunciation and may violate the semantic distinction of words:

б ы л → б и л

м ы → м и

Difficulties also manifest themselves in the distinction of softness of consonants:

угол — уголь

брат — брать

To overcome phonetic interference, systematic work with minimal pairs, articulatory exercises, and the development of phonemic perception is necessary (Shcherba 1974: 105–108).

6.3. Lexico-Semantic Interference

The lexical level represents a significant area of interference, since errors are connected not only with insufficient knowledge of words but also with differences in the semantic organization of Russian and Persian (Karaulov 1987: 52–54).

Particular difficulty is presented by Russian verbs of motion:

идти — ходить

ехать — ездить

нести — носить

In Persian these meanings are expressed by other linguistic means; therefore learners may use a single Russian form instead of several forms that differ in direction, repetition, or manner of action.

Difficulties also arise in the study of the category of verbal aspect:

читать — прочитать

писать — написать

The absence of a complete correspondence to the Russian aspectual opposition leads to the mixing of the meanings of completeness and duration of an action (Maslov 1987: 214–216).

6.4. Syntactic and Communicative Interference

The results of the study show that interference also manifests itself at the level of utterance construction. One of the causes of the emergence of syntactic errors is the difference in the organization of the sentence.

Persian is characterized by the model:

S + O + V

(subject + object + predicate)

For example:

من کتاب را می‌خوانم

(I the book read)

In Russian, word order is freer; however, a change in sentence structure is connected with actual division, the semantic highlighting of information, and the communicative intention of the speaker (Maslov 1987: 301–303).

Persian-speaking learners may transfer the structure of the native language into Russian speech, which leads to a violation of the natural word order. In addition, differences in speech etiquette may cause communicative errors in the use of forms of address, requests, gratitude, and refusal (Galskova & Gez 2006: 215–217).

Error analysis shows that many deviations from the norm are systemic in character and are connected precisely with cross-linguistic transfer. Errors of the type:

н о в ы й книга

ч и т а т ь книга

are conditioned by the absence in Persian of the categories of grammatical gender and case inflection. Therefore, error analysis performs not only a diagnostic but also a teaching function, making it possible to predict learners' difficulties and to develop special exercises (Selinker 1972: 214–216).

The main types of identified interference and ways of overcoming them are presented in Table 3.

Table 3

Main Types of Russian-Persian Interference and Ways of Overcoming Them

Type of Interference	Cause of Emergence	Example of Error	Method of Correction
Phonetic	Absence of the sounds [y], soft consonants	был → бил	Articulatory exercises, minimal pairs
Gender of nouns	Absence of the category of gender in Persian	новый книга	Agreement tables, practical tasks
Case system	Absence of an analogous system in Persian	читать книга	Contrastive exercises with government models
Verbal aspect	No complete correspondence of the category of aspect	я сделал/делал	Contextual exercises
Verbs of motion	Differences in semantic organization	я иду каждый день пешком (instead of хожу)	Communicative tasks
Word order	Difference in sentence models	Transfer of SOV structure	Work with actual division

Thus, the results of the study confirm that Russian-Persian interference is a multilevel phenomenon encompassing the phonetic, lexical, grammatical, syntactic, and communicative levels. The most effective way of overcoming it is a comprehensive approach that includes contrastive analysis, systematic work on errors, and the formation in learners of a conscious understanding of the differences between the native and the target language.

6.5. Error Analysis as a Tool for Identifying and Overcoming Interference

Error analysis is an important method of investigating the process of the acquisition of Russian as a foreign language and makes it possible to identify the causes of interference among Persian-speaking learners. In modern methodology, errors are regarded not only as deviations from the linguistic norm but also as an indicator of the formation of the learner's intermediate language system (Selinker 1972: 214).

Analysis of speech shows that the majority of errors are connected with the transfer of features of Persian. The most widespread difficulties arise in the use of cases, the agreement of words, the choice of verbal aspect, and the use of verbs of motion.

It is important to distinguish interference errors from errors caused by insufficient mastery of the material. For example, errors of the type "новый книга" and "читать книга" are conditioned by the absence in Persian of the categories of gender and case inflection. Such an approach corresponds to the principles of contrastive analysis, which make it possible to predict typical learning difficulties (Lado 1957: 34–36).

The practical application of error analysis includes the correction of typical errors, the comparison of Russian and Persian constructions, and the use of contrastive exercises. This contributes to the development of learners' linguistic awareness and increases the effectiveness of teaching (Shchukin 2003: 145–147).

Thus, error analysis performs diagnostic and teaching functions, helping to identify the main zones of interference and to improve the methodology of teaching Russian as a foreign language.

7. Methodological Strategies for Overcoming Interference

The effectiveness of teaching Russian as a foreign language largely depends on the extent to which the teacher takes into account the features of the learners' native language. For Persian-speaking students, differences between the Russian and Persian language systems become the cause of persistent interference errors; therefore their prevention should be regarded as one of the main tasks of the teaching process.

The contrastive analysis of Russian and Persian makes it possible to determine in advance the most problematic linguistic phenomena and to structure teaching with possible difficulties in mind. Such an approach corresponds to the principles of modern

linguodidactics, according to which the teaching of a foreign language should take into account the linguistic experience of learners and the features of the interaction of the native and the target languages (Galskova & Gez 2006: 92–94).

In modern methodology of teaching Russian as a foreign language, the overcoming of interference is regarded not only as the correction of already arisen errors but primarily as their prevention. Such an approach presupposes the consistent formation of linguistic skills on the basis of the conscious comparison of elements of the native and the target languages. Thanks to this, learners not only acquire grammatical rules but also understand the reasons for their use in various communicative situations (Shchukin 2003: 58–60).

The use of contrastive analysis in the teaching process allows the teacher to predict typical difficulties, to develop special exercises, and to adapt teaching materials to the features of a concrete group of learners.

7.1. The Contrastive Approach in Teaching

The contrastive approach occupies an important place in teaching Russian to Persian-speaking students. Its main goal consists in identifying differences between language systems and using the results of contrastive analysis in the development of teaching materials and practical tasks (Lado 1957: 25–30).

In teaching phonetics it is recommended to use exercises aimed at distinguishing sounds that are absent in Persian, above all the vowel [y], as well as hard and soft consonants. Effective are exercises with minimal pairs, repeated listening to speech samples, and phonetic repetition after a native speaker (Sokolova & Ganshina 1980: 110–112).

In the process of studying grammar it is advisable to apply tasks based on the comparison of Russian and Persian constructions. Particular attention should be paid to categories that have no direct analogues in Persian: grammatical gender, the case system, the agreement of words, and the category of verbal aspect. The consistent comparison of analogous constructions helps learners consciously acquire new grammatical models and reduces the influence of the native language.

For the formation of lexical competence it is useful to use exercises aimed at the analysis of word meaning, combinability, and features of use in various contexts. An important role is played by tasks connected with verbs of motion, aspectual pairs, and set expressions, since it is precisely these groups of words that most frequently cause interference errors.

Thus, the contrastive approach makes it possible to turn differences between Russian and Persian from a source of difficulties into an object of conscious learning. Its application contributes to the formation of stable linguistic skills and a reduction in the number of interference errors among Persian-speaking students.

7.2. Practical Recommendations for Teachers of RFL

The organization of teaching Russian as a foreign language should take into account the degree of complexity of various linguistic phenomena for Persian-speaking students. At the initial stage it is recommended to devote particular attention to phonetic skills, since the correct perception and pronunciation of Russian sounds create the foundation for the further formation of communicative competence (Sokolova & Ganshina 1980: 15–18).

The study of grammatical categories should be carried out in stages, combining the explanation of rules with a large number of practical exercises. When introducing case forms, the category of gender, and the agreement of words, it is important to use visual schemes, tables, speech samples, and communicative tasks that allow the studied constructions to be applied in real situations of communication. Such an approach contributes to a more conscious acquisition of the grammatical system of Russian (Shchukin 2003: 120–122).

Of particular importance is the systematic analysis of learners' typical errors. Regular discussion of the causes of their emergence helps to form skills of self-control and contributes to a more conscious mastery of Russian. The correction of errors should be accompanied by an explanation of the differences between the Russian and Persian language systems and should not be limited to pointing out a violation of the norm (Selinker 1972: 214–216).

An additional means of increasing the effectiveness of teaching is the use of authentic texts, audio and video materials, as well as tasks that model real communicative situations. Such an approach contributes to the development not only of linguistic but also of sociocultural competence necessary for successful communication in Russian (Galskova & Gez 2006: 215–217).

It should be taken into account that the effectiveness of the proposed methodological strategies depends on the level of proficiency in Russian, the individual features of the learners, and the conditions of organization of the teaching process. Therefore the choice of concrete methods and types of exercises should be made with regard to the aims of

teaching, the linguistic preparation of the students, and the communicative tasks of each stage of instruction.

Thus, the overcoming of Russian-Persian language interference requires a comprehensive approach that unites contrastive analysis, systematic work on typical errors, communicative practice, and consideration of the features of the learners' native language. The realization of these methodological strategies contributes to increasing the effectiveness of teaching Russian as a foreign language and to the development of stable communicative competence of Persian-speaking students.

8. Conclusion

Russian-Persian language interference is a natural result of the interaction of two language systems in the process of studying Russian as a foreign language. The research conducted has shown that interference phenomena cover all the main levels of language: phonetic, lexico-semantic, grammatical, syntactic, and communicative.

The results of the contrastive analysis of Russian and Persian confirmed that the main difficulties of Persian-speaking learners are connected with substantial structural differences between the two language systems. The most problematic areas are the absence of grammatical gender and a case system in Persian, differences in the organization of the phonological system, features of the category of verbal aspect, the system of verbs of motion, as well as differences in word order and speech norms of communication.

Error analysis showed that the majority of typical deviations from the norms of the Russian language are systemic in character and are conditioned by the transfer of elements of the native language into the process of mastering the foreign language. This confirms the necessity of regarding errors not only as a result of insufficient mastery of the material but also as a source of information about the mechanisms of the formation of learners' linguistic competence (Selinker 1972: 214–216).

The contrastive approach possesses significant methodological potential, since it makes it possible to predict possible learning difficulties, to develop special exercises, and to adapt teaching materials to the features of a Persian-speaking audience. The use of contrastive analysis contributes to the formation of a conscious attitude of learners toward the

differences between the native and the target language and reduces the influence of negative transfer (Lado 1957: 34–36).

Thus, effective teaching of Russian as a foreign language to Persian-speaking students requires a comprehensive approach that unites contrastive analysis, error analysis, systematic work on pronunciation, grammatical skills, lexical combinability, and communicative strategies.

Prospects for further research are connected with the development of experimental methodologies of teaching Russian for Persian-speaking students, the creation of specialized teaching materials, and the study of the influence of interference on various stages of the formation of Russian-language communicative competence.

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